

► **USB connection:** While all Windows Phones will need to provide some way to charge the device, Microsoft doesn't specify the type of connection that will be used. The result is that different Windows Phones unfortunately will use different power/charge connections, most of which are some variation of USB outlets. In conjunction with a compatible cable, you can charge your phone via a PC, or with a USB power adapter, via a standard wall receptacle. One useful feature that Microsoft doesn't support, let alone require, is the Zune dock connector that the company previously used on its line of Zune portable media players. This connector worked exactly like Apple's popular dock connector, which provides iPod, iPad and iPhone users with a standard connector type. You won't find a Windows Phone with a Zune dock connector.

You get the idea: Microsoft specifies some of the more important Windows Phone hardware features in order to provide a consistent experience for users. But Windows Phone also leaves a lot up to the device makers, so there will still be some variation between Windows Phones and, unfortunately, even some areas where Windows Phones simply fall short, at least until Microsoft adds support for certain missing functionality.

With Microsoft's previous mobile platform, Windows Mobile, device makers and wireless carriers were able to further differentiate their wares by adding custom software solutions or by actually



A slide keyboard on LG Quantum

replacing the tired Windows Mobile user interface with a UI "shell" the way HTC Sense does. Microsoft doesn't allow this level of customisation in Windows Phone – part of its effort to exert more control over the platform and ensure that customers have a consistent experience, regardless of which device they use. However, device makers and wireless carriers are allowed to offer far more subtle customisations via software applications, which run under Windows Phone. Except in rare instances, these apps shouldn't be considered true differentiators, and can instead be ignored.